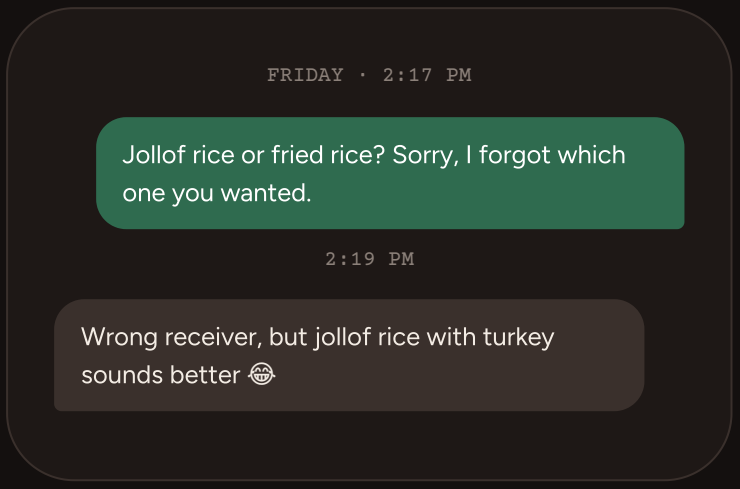
AN ORIGINAL NIGERIAN DRAMA

# The Wrong Number

## She texted the wrong number... 10 years later, the stranger appeared at her wedding.

Abuja. A wife so afraid of her husband that she can't choose what to cook. Lagos. A witty stranger who answers a text that was never meant for her. Ten years of Fridays. Two women who have never seen each other's faces.




| 58 | ~50 | 100% | 3 |
|---|---|---|---|
| SCENES | MINUTES | DIALOGUE | ACTS |

# The cast

**CHLOE ADEYEMI**

(33 → 43). A beautiful, intelligent woman in Abuja and a trained interior designer who stopped designing. She has learned to apologise even when she has done nothing wrong. → first appears in Scene 1

**EMMA WILLIAMS**

(35 → 45). Department manager at an AI production studio in Lagos. Single, witty and blunt. Kind without being sentimental. → first appears in Scene 2

**BISI**

Emma's colleague and friend. → first appears in Scene 2

**ZAINAB**

Chloe's lawyer. → first appears in Scene 32

**MAMA EMMA**

Emma's mother. → first appears in Scene 14

**GUESTS**

, CLIENT, COUNSELLOR, JUDGE, MC, KUNLE'S LAWYER.

**KUNLE ADEYEMI**

(38). Chloe's husband, a respected businessman. Charming in public and controlling in private. He uses money, criticism and intimidation, and he doesn't believe he's doing anything wrong. → first appears in Scene 1

**ADA**

(7 → 17) and TOBI (4 → 14). Chloe's children. → first appears in Scene 1

**HALIMA**

Chloe's old university friend. → first appears in Scene 18

**TUNDE BALOGUN**

An architect, warm and patient.

**AUNTY BOLA**

Kunle's elder sister. → first appears in Scene 34

# Follow a story thread

Tap a scene number to jump straight to it.

## The First Text

One wrong digit, one stranger, and a laugh she had forgotten.

SCENE 1 SCENE 2 SCENE 5 SCENE 6

## The Woman She Used to Be

The portfolio, the house with no windows and the first paid job.

SCENE 9 SCENE 16 SCENE 17 SCENE 21 SCENE 22

## Life With Kunle

Control without fists: receipts, collars and a blocked card.

SCENE 3 SCENE 4 SCENE 11 SCENE 25 SCENE 27

## Asking for Help

Halima, the counsellor and a lawyer who listens.

SCENE 12 SCENE 18 SCENE 19 SCENE 20 SCENE 32

## Emma's Side

The studio, her mother, her birthday and the jobs she saved.

SCENE 13 SCENE 14 SCENE 23 SCENE 24 SCENE 42

## Leaving

Three silent Fridays, a suitcase and a quiet house.

SCENE 28 SCENE 29 SCENE 30 SCENE 31

## The Court

His call, his sister, the hearing and home.

SCENE 33 SCENE 34 SCENE 36 SCENE 38 SCENE 39

## Tunde

Coffee, both kinds of rice, a full-sentence no and the window.

SCENE 44 SCENE 46 SCENE 47 SCENE 48

## The Wedding

Ten years, no face, and two words.

SCENE 50 SCENE 51 SCENE 52 SCENE 53 SCENE 54 SCENE 55 SCENE 58

**How to use this PDF**

- Tap any scene in the contents, or any scene number in a thread, to jump to it. Your PDF app's bookmarks list every scene too.
- Every scene has ◀ **Previous**, **All scenes** and **Next** ▶ links at the top.
- Text messages appear as chat bubbles: Chloe on the right in green, everyone else on the left. Every Friday text sits at the same minute: 2:19 PM.
- Every scene has three **production checkboxes** (Images, Voice, Edited). Tick them as you make the video. They save with the PDF in most PDF apps.

# Scenes

## ACT ONE — THE MESSAGE THAT WENT ASTRAY


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 01 | "Jollof or Fried Rice?" | 0:00 |
| 02 | Wrong Receiver | 0:59 |
| 03 | Too Much Pepper | 1:42 |
| 04 | The Morning Inspection | 2:20 |
| 05 | "You Simply Have Bad Taste" | 3:06 |
| 06 | Friday Stranger | 3:51 |
| 07 | "Who Is Making You Smile?" | 4:10 |
| 08 | Rice Woman | 4:39 |
| 09 | The Portfolio | 5:18 |
| 10 | The First Call | 5:59 |


## ACT TWO — THE WOMAN BEHIND THE MESSAGES


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 11 | "She Would Forget Her Own Head" | 6:58 |
| 12 | "I Think I'm Afraid of Him" | 7:41 |
| 13 | "Who Is She?" | 8:54 |
| 14 | Emma's Birthday | 9:52 |
| 15 | "Please Don't Disappear" | 10:38 |
| 16 | A House Without Windows | 11:34 |
| 17 | "Remove That Sorry" | 12:12 |
| 18 | The Call to Halima | 12:59 |
| 19 | The First Step | 13:42 |
| 20 | The Counsellor | 15:05 |
| 21 | The Workshop | 16:30 |
| 22 | "Someone Paid Me" | 17:08 |
| 23 | Now It's My Turn | 17:48 |
| 24 | Six Names | 19:09 |
| 25 | "Who Gave You Permission?" | 20:15 |
| 26 | "My Voice Was Shaking" | 21:04 |
| 27 | The Card | 22:29 |
| 28 | Three Fridays | 23:09 |
| 29 | What Happened in Abuja | 23:42 |
| 30 | "I'm Still Here" | 24:44 |
| 31 | The Borrowed Bed | 25:59 |
| 32 | "I Want My Children" | 26:38 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 33 | The Call From Kunle | 28:17 |
| 34 | "What Will People Say?" | 29:04 |
| 35 | The Edge of Something Enormous | 30:15 |
| 36 | The Hearing | 30:49 |
| 37 | "I Am So Tired" | 32:36 |
| 38 | "Let's Go Home" | 33:08 |
| 39 | The Handover | 33:56 |


> *ACT THREE — LEARNING TO LIVE AGAIN*


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 40 | A Room of Her Own | 34:41 |
| 41 | Seven Years, No Face | 35:30 |
| 42 | Mummy's Question | 36:17 |
| 43 | Still Here | 37:15 |
| 44 | "Coffee?" | 37:50 |
| 45 | "Excuse Me???" | 38:39 |
| 46 | The Boy who Likes Both | 39:36 |
| 47 | "Not Yet" | 40:13 |
| 48 | The Window | 40:58 |
| 49 | "He Asked" | 41:45 |
| 50 | "Please Come" | 42:10 |
| 51 | What If? | 42:42 |
| 52 | Arrivals | 43:30 |
| 53 | The Bride's Room | 44:00 |
| 54 | The Stranger who Answered | 44:52 |
| 55 | "Still Here" | 47:34 |
| 56 | Aunty Friday | 48:04 |
| 57 | The First Dance | 49:18 |
| 58 | Jollof With Turkey | 49:45 |

ACT ONE

# The Message That Went Astray

SCENE 1 OF 58 · 0:00–0:59

# "Jollof or Fried Rice?"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE, ABUJA — KITCHEN — FRIDAY, 2:14 PM — YEAR ONE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

*Abuja, early afternoon. The camera glides through the gates of a large white house in Asokoro, past a manicured lawn and a parked black SUV, into a spotless kitchen. The extractor fan hums. A pot of rice simmers. A woman moves between the stove, the fridge and her children with the careful speed of someone who cannot afford a mistake.*

*A beautiful, expensive kitchen with marble counters, fresh flowers and everything perfect. Everything except the woman standing in it. CHLOE ADEYEMI (33) stirs a pot while ADA (7) does homework at the counter and TOBI (4) pushes a toy car across the floor. Chloe's phone rings: "KUNLE."*

**KUNLE** (ON PHONE) Chloe. I hope you've started preparing my dinner.

**CHLOE** Yes, darling. I'm just trying to remember which—

**KUNLE** (ON PHONE) You mean you've forgotten what we discussed this morning?

**CHLOE** No, no, I remember. I just wanted to be sure.

**KUNLE** (ON PHONE) It's amazing how you can spend the whole day in this house and still not remember one simple instruction.

*Click. Chloe stares at the phone.*

**ADA** *(not looking up)* Mummy, are you in trouble?

**CHLOE** No, sweetheart. Mummy just forgot something.

**ADA** You always say sorry to Daddy.

*Chloe freezes. The words land harder than they should.*

**CHLOE** Finish your homework, darling.

**TOBI** Mummy, I want jollof!

**CHLOE** *(a tired smile)* Everybody wants something today.

*She picks up a brand-new phone. The old one died this morning. She types Kunle's number from memory, her fingers trembling. One digit is wrong.*

CHLOE
Jollof rice or fried rice? Sorry, I forgot which one you wanted.

*Send. 2:17 PM. She grips the counter and waits. 2:19 PM. Buzz.*

UNKNOWN

Wrong receiver, but jollof rice with turkey sounds better 😂

> *Chloe blinks and looks at the number. Oh no. A stranger.*

**CHLOE** *(whispering)* Wrong receiver?

> *And for the first time all afternoon, a tiny smile escapes her. Then a car pulls up outside. A door slams. The smile vanishes.*

**ADA** *(quietly)* Daddy's home early.

SCENE 2 OF 58 · 0:59–1:42

# Wrong Receiver

INT. AI PRODUCTION STUDIO, LAGOS — BREAK ROOM — SAME FRIDAY, 2:20 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Lagos, the same afternoon. Horns blare on Admiralty Way as the camera rises to the third floor of a glass building. Inside the AI production studio, young creatives in headphones sit at glowing screens, and someone laughs in the corridor. The break room smells of takeaway jollof and coffee.*

> *A busy, colourful studio with screens showing half-finished animated scenes. EMMA WILLIAMS (35) eats rice from a takeaway pack while reviewing a sequence on her tablet. She's grinning at her phone. BISI, her colleague, leans over.*

**BISI** What's funny?

**EMMA** Someone just asked me whether to cook jollof or fried rice.

**BISI** And what did you say?

**EMMA** Jollof with turkey, obviously.

**BISI** You're advising strangers now?

**EMMA** Food is a serious matter, Bisi. Somebody has to help. *(beat)* She sounded scared, though.

**BISI** Scared? Of rice?

**EMMA** *(looking at the message again)* "Sorry, I forgot which one you wanted." *(beat)* Who says sorry to their own husband about rice?

**BISI** *(shrugging)* Lagos people say sorry for everything.

**EMMA** *(putting the phone down)* Hmm.

> *A colleague calls from the door: "Emma! The client wants the dragon to be purple now!"*

**EMMA** *(groaning)* Purple. Of course. Why not.

SCENE 3 OF 58 · 1:42–2:20

# Too Much Pepper

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — DINING ROOM — SAME NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Night falls over Abuja. Inside the Adeyemi dining room, a crystal chandelier hangs over a long, polished table. The only sounds are cutlery against china and the ticking of a wall clock. Chloe sits at the far end, her back straight and her plate barely touched.*

> *A long, polished table. Kunle eats in silence. Chloe watches every spoonful. The children eat quietly.*

**KUNLE** *(putting his spoon down)* Chloe.

**CHLOE** Yes, darling?

**KUNLE** What is this?

**CHLOE** Jollof rice. You said this morning—

**KUNLE** I know what I said. I'm asking what this is. *(He pushes the plate an inch away.)* Too much pepper. Too much oil. Is it so difficult to follow one instruction?

**CHLOE** I'm sorry. I'll make it again tomorrow. Less pepper.

**KUNLE** You always say tomorrow.

> *He stands and leaves the table. Ada looks at her mother's untouched plate.*

**ADA** *(whispering)* Mummy, I liked it.

**CHLOE** *(squeezing her hand)* Thank you, baby.

**TOBI** *(mouth full)* Me too! Jollof is the best!

> *Chloe laughs softly, then stops herself and looks toward the door Kunle went through.*

SCENE 4 OF 58 · 2:20–3:06

# The Morning Inspection

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — DINING ROOM / FRONT DOOR — MONDAY, 6:45 AM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Monday dawn. Pale light spreads across the marble floor of the entrance hall. Kunle comes down the staircase in a crisp suit, buttoning his cuffs, and every footstep echoes. At the bottom, his family waits in a neat line, like staff before an inspection.*

> *Kunle, dressed for work, checks his shirt cuffs. Chloe hands him a lunch box and his briefcase. Ada and Tobi, in school uniforms, stand in a line like soldiers.*

**KUNLE** *(inspecting Ada's collar)* Who ironed this?

**CHLOE** I did, darling.

**KUNLE** It has a crease. *(to Ada)* Tell your mother that a crease on your collar is a crease on my name.

**ADA** *(quietly)* Yes, Daddy.

**KUNLE** *(holding out his hand)* The receipts from Saturday's market.

> *Chloe hands him a small bundle of receipts. He flicks through them.*

**KUNLE** Eight thousand naira for tomatoes?

**CHLOE** Prices have gone up, darling. Everybody is complaining.

**KUNLE** Everybody isn't spending my money. *(He pockets the receipts.)* Next time, bring the change and the receipt together. *(He kisses Tobi's head.)* Be good, champion.

> *The door closes. Chloe exhales for the first time in ten minutes. Ada looks at her.*

**ADA** Mummy, I'll iron my own collar from now on.

**CHLOE** *(kneeling, fixing it)* No, baby. Your collar was perfect. *(beat)* It was perfect.

SCENE 5 OF 58 · 3:06–3:51

# "You Simply Have Bad Taste"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — BEDROOM / INT. EMMA'S DESK, LAGOS — INTERCUT — THE NEXT FRIDAY, 2:19 PM

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The next Friday. Afternoon sun falls through the bedroom curtains onto a bed covered in folded laundry. Chloe works in silence. In Lagos, Emma sits at a cluttered desk covered in sticky notes, a film sequence paused on her monitor.*

> *Chloe folds laundry on the bed. Her phone lies beside her. She scrolls back to the stranger's message and reads it again. She hesitates, then types fast before she can change her mind.*

CHLOE
Jollof rice was the wrong option. Next time try fried rice.

> *In Lagos, Emma's phone buzzes on her desk. She grins.*

EMMA
No. The person simply has bad taste 😂

CHLOE
You don't know him.

EMMA
True. But anyone who complains about good jollof is already suspicious.

CHLOE
You're funny.

EMMA
Only on Fridays. Monday to Thursday, I'm a very serious woman.

> *Chloe laughs. Not a polite laugh. A real, unexpected, beautiful laugh. Ada appears in the doorway.*

**ADA** Mummy! You're laughing!

**CHLOE** *(surprised at herself)* Yes, baby. I suppose I am.

**ADA** Why?

**CHLOE** Someone said something funny.

**ADA** Who?

**CHLOE** *(looking at the phone)* Nobody, really. A stranger.

**ADA** Can the stranger say something funny again tomorrow?

**CHLOE** *(smiling)* Maybe next Friday.

SCENE 6 OF 58 · 3:51–4:10

# Friday Stranger

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — BEDROOM — LATE NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Late night. The house is dark except for the blue glow of a phone screen. The air conditioner hums. Kunle sleeps on his back on the far side of a wide bed. Chloe sits on the very edge, as far from him as the mattress allows.*

> *The children are asleep. Kunle snores on the far side of the bed. Chloe sits on the edge of the bed with her phone glowing in the dark. She opens the unknown number, taps "Add contact" and types a name: "FRIDAY STRANGER." She looks at it for a long time.*

**CHLOE** *(whispering to herself)* What are you doing, Chloe?

> *Kunle shifts in his sleep.*

**KUNLE** *(mumbling)* Who are you talking to?

**CHLOE** *(locking the phone instantly)* Nobody, darling. Go back to sleep.

> *She lies down, holding the phone against her chest.*

SCENE 7 OF 58 · 4:10–4:39

# "Who Is Making You Smile?"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — SITTING ROOM — EVENING — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Early evening, weeks later. Golden light comes through the tall windows of the sitting room. The television plays the news on low. Chloe curls up on the cream sofa with her feet tucked under her, a small, rare smile on her face. Behind her, the front door opens quietly.*

> *Chloe sits on the sofa reading a message and smiling. She doesn't notice Kunle standing in the doorway, watching.*

**KUNLE** Who is making you smile like that?

**CHLOE** *(locking the phone, too quickly)* Nobody. It's… a recipe group. Women share recipes.

**KUNLE** *(walking slowly toward her)* A recipe group. *(beat)* Then why don't your recipes improve?

> *He holds out his hand for the phone. Chloe's heart pounds. Then his own phone rings: "CHIEF OKEKE." He looks at it, then at her.*

**KUNLE** *(answering, suddenly warm)* Chief! Good evening, sir!

> *He walks out of the room, laughing on the call. Chloe sits frozen with the phone against her chest.*

> *She opens FRIDAY STRANGER.*

CHLOE
I have to go. Talk next Friday.

EMMA
Everything okay?

CHLOE
Yes. Sorry.

> *She deletes the conversation from her screen, then opens the contact and looks at the name: "FRIDAY STRANGER." She doesn't delete that.*

SCENE 8 OF 58 · 4:39–5:18

# Rice Woman

MONTAGE — LAGOS AND ABUJA — FRIDAYS OVER THREE WEEKS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A sequence of Fridays. The camera cuts between two cities: yellow danfo buses crawling through Lagos traffic, wide clean Abuja roads under blue sky, Emma striding into meetings, Chloe packing lunch boxes. Each Friday, a phone lights up.*

> *FRIDAY ONE. Lagos traffic and Abuja sunshine. Emma in a meeting, Chloe packing school lunches.*

CHLOE
Serious question. Is pineapple on pizza a crime?

EMMA
An international offence. Who committed it?

CHLOE
My daughter.

EMMA
She's young. Rehabilitation is possible.

> *FRIDAY TWO. Emma arguing with an editor over a film scene, then checking her phone and smiling.*

EMMA
How was your week, Rice Woman?

CHLOE
Don't call me that 😂

EMMA
Then tell me your name.

> *Chloe hesitates. She looks around the empty kitchen as if someone might be watching.*

CHLOE
Chloe.

EMMA
Emma. Nice to meet you, Chloe of the disputed jollof.

CHLOE

Nice to meet you, Emma who gives unsolicited rice advice.

EMMA

Solicited. You texted ME, madam.

SCENE 9 OF 58 · 5:18–5:59

# The Portfolio

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — BEDROOM / EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — INTERCUT — FRIDAY THREE, NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Friday night. The Adeyemi house is asleep. A single bedside lamp throws a small circle of light on the carpet where Chloe sits cross-legged, her back against the wardrobe. In Lagos, Emma lies on a worn sofa in a small, cosy flat, eating cereal from the box.*

> *Chloe sits on the bedroom floor in the dark. Emma lies on her sofa in Lagos, eating cereal for dinner.*

CHLOE
Can I ask you something that isn't about food?

EMMA
That would be a first. Go on.

CHLOE
Do you think people can forget who they used to be?

> *Emma stops chewing. She sits up.*

EMMA
Yes. But I don't think the old person disappears completely.

CHLOE
How do you find them again?

> *A long pause. Emma thinks carefully.*

EMMA
Perhaps you start by remembering one thing that used to make you happy.

> *Chloe looks up. On the top shelf of her wardrobe, behind old handbags, is a dusty folder. She stands on a chair and pulls it down. She blows off the dust. The first page reads: "CHLOE ADEYEMI — INTERIOR DESIGN PORTFOLIO." Sketches of beautiful rooms, colour palettes and photographs. Her own handwriting from another life. She runs her fingers over the letters.*

**CHLOE** *(whispering)* Hello, you.

CHLOE
I think I remember something.

EMMA

Then that's something worth keeping.

> *Chloe holds the portfolio against her chest like something she has rescued.*

SCENE 10 OF 58 · 5:59–6:58

# The First Call

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — LAUNDRY ROOM / EMMA'S BALCONY, LAGOS — SATURDAY AFTERNOON

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Saturday afternoon. Kunle's car pulls out of the gate, golf clubs rattling in the boot. The house relaxes. In the laundry room at the back, the washing machine rumbles through its cycle. Chloe closes the door behind her and leans against it.*

> *Kunle has gone to play golf. The washing machine rumbles. Chloe stands among piles of laundry with her phone.*

EMMA
Random question. Can I hear your voice? Just to prove you're not an AI. I work in an AI studio. I'm suspicious of everybody.

CHLOE
😂 Okay. Once. Quickly.

> *Chloe presses call. It rings once.*

**EMMA** *(laughing)* Hello? Is this the famous Rice Woman?

**CHLOE** *(shy, giggling)* This is Chloe.

**EMMA** Oh! You have a lovely voice! I was expecting someone much more… guilty about rice.

**CHLOE** *(laughing)* And you sound exactly like your texts. Loud.

**EMMA** Lagos made me loud. You can't survive Third Mainland Bridge whispering.

> *They both laugh. Then a short silence.*

**CHLOE** *(quietly)* It's strange. Hearing you. It makes you… real.

**EMMA** *(softly)* I am real, Chloe. Every Friday. I'm a real person on the other side of this phone.

> *The washing machine stops. Silence. Chloe glances at the door.*

**CHLOE** I should go.

**EMMA** Go. Same time next Friday?

**CHLOE** Same time next Friday.

ACT TWO

# The Woman Behind the Messages

SCENE 11 OF 58 · 6:58–7:41

# "She Would Forget Her Own Head"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — DINING ROOM — FRIDAY NIGHT — NINE MONTHS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Nine months later. A Friday-night dinner party. The dining room glows with candles, white lilies stand in tall vases, and every chair is filled. Three businessmen in agbada and their wives in shimmering lace laugh around the table. Chloe, in a simple dress, moves silently from guest to guest with serving dishes, refilling, clearing and smiling.*

> *A dinner party. Kunle entertains three business associates and their wives. Chloe has cooked every dish, arranged the flowers and set every glass. She moves around the table serving.*

**GUEST** Kunle, this egusi is excellent! Your wife should open a restaurant!

**KUNLE** *(smiling warmly)* Please, don't encourage her. If you leave Chloe alone, she'd forget her own head. I have to supervise everything in this house.

> *Everyone laughs. Chloe smiles too.*

**GUEST'S WIFE** Chloe, didn't you study design? I remember your wedding. Those decorations!

**CHLOE** *(brightening)* Yes! Interior design. I used to love—

**KUNLE** *(cutting in smoothly)* That was a long time ago. Chloe's full-time job now is making sure I don't starve. *(Laughter.)* Darling, the dessert.

**CHLOE** *(the light going out of her face)* Yes, darling.

SCENE 12 OF 58 · 7:41–8:54

# "I Think I'm Afraid of Him"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — BEDROOM — SAME NIGHT, LATER / INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Midnight. The last guest's car leaves through the gate. The candles have burnt down and the dirty plates are stacked in the kitchen. Upstairs in the bedroom, Kunle stands at the mirror, his reflection stern under the bright ceiling light, while Chloe hovers by the door.*

> *The guests are gone. Kunle loosens his tie in front of the mirror.*

**KUNLE** Why did you interrupt when I was explaining the contract to Chief Okeke?

**CHLOE** I was only answering his wife's question—

**KUNLE** You always have an explanation.

> *Chloe looks down at the carpet.*

**CHLOE** I'm sorry.

> *He walks out. Chloe sits on the edge of the bed and opens FRIDAY STRANGER.*

CHLOE
Emma, can I ask you something?

EMMA
Anything.

CHLOE
Can someone make you feel useless without ever saying the word "useless"?

> *In Lagos, Emma puts down her dinner.*

**EMMA** *(quietly)* Oh, Chloe.

EMMA
Yes. How someone treats you matters as much as the words they use.

CHLOE
What if everyone thinks he's wonderful?

EMMA
They're judging the person they see. You're living with the person you know.

*A long silence. Then Chloe types the words she has never said out loud.*

CHLOE
I think I'm afraid of my husband.

*Emma doesn't reply immediately. She stands up and paces her living room. Then she types.*

EMMA
Chloe, are you and the children safe right now?

CHLOE
Yes. He's asleep.

EMMA
I'm glad. You don't have to decide anything tonight. But you shouldn't have to live in fear. Is there anyone in Abuja you trust enough to talk to?

CHLOE
I used to have friends.

EMMA
Perhaps one of them is still waiting to hear from you.

*Chloe scrolls through her contacts to a name: "HALIMA (UNI)." The last message between them is nearly three years old. Her thumb hovers over the call button. It hovers. It hovers.*

SCENE 13 OF 58 · 8:54–9:52

# "Who Is She?"

INT. AI STUDIO, LAGOS — EMMA'S DESK — NEXT MORNING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Morning in Lagos. The studio is waking up: coffee machines hiss, monitors flicker on, and someone plays Afrobeats from a laptop. Emma sits slumped at her desk with dark circles under her eyes, staring at her phone. Bisi walks over carrying two paper cups.*

> *Emma hasn't slept much. Bisi drops a coffee on her desk.*

**BISI** You look like you edited all night.

**EMMA** I didn't sleep. The rice woman.

**BISI** The Abuja one? You're still texting her? It's been nine months, Emma.

**EMMA** She told me last night she's afraid of her husband.

> *Bisi slowly sits down.*

**BISI** *(serious now)* Emma. Be careful. You don't know these people. You don't know her. You don't even know her surname.

**EMMA** I know she says "sorry" more than anybody I've ever met. *(beat)* I know she laughs like she's not allowed to.

**BISI** And what can you do from Lagos?

**EMMA** *(quietly)* Listen. That's all. I can listen.

**BISI** *(after a pause)* Then listen properly. And make sure she has real people there, not just a phone.

**EMMA** *(nodding)* That's exactly what I told her.

SCENE 14 OF 58 · 9:52–10:38

# Emma's Birthday

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — NIGHT — HER 36TH BIRTHDAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Night in Lagos. Emma's small apartment is quiet. Rain taps on the window. She has laid out one plate, one cupcake and one candle on a small round table. She sits down alone in front of them.*

> *Emma sits alone at her small dining table with one cupcake and one candle. Her phone rings: "MUMMY."*

**MAMA EMMA** (ON PHONE) Happy birthday, my daughter! Thirty-six! *(beat)* Emma, when are you going to bring a husband home? Your cousin Funmi has three children now.

**EMMA** *(sighing)* Mummy, I have a career.

**MAMA EMMA** (ON PHONE) A career won't hold your hand when you're old.

**EMMA** *(quietly)* I know, Mummy.

> *She hangs up. She lights the candle and looks at it. Her phone buzzes again: a voice note from FRIDAY. She plays it. Chloe's voice is singing softly, a little off-key, in a whisper.*

**CHLOE** (VOICE NOTE) *(whispering, singing)* Happy birthday to you… happy birthday, dear Emma… *(She giggles.)* Sorry, I have to whisper, the children are asleep. *(beat)* You remembered my daughter's birthday last month. I wasn't going to forget yours. *(beat)* Make a wish. A big one.

> *Emma laughs out loud, alone in her flat, and wipes her eyes. She blows out the candle.*

**EMMA** *(whispering to the empty room)* Thank you, Rice Woman.

SCENE 15 OF 58 · 10:38–11:34

# "Please Don't Disappear"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE / AI STUDIO, LAGOS — INTERCUT — FRIDAY — ONE YEAR AFTER THE FIRST MESSAGE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *One year after the first message. A Friday. In Lagos, Emma rushes from one glass-walled meeting room to the next with a laptop under her arm, her phone face down in her pocket. In Abuja, Chloe stands alone at the kitchen counter, staring at her phone, waiting.*

> *Emma is buried in back-to-back meetings with her phone face down. In Abuja, Chloe waits at the kitchen counter.*

CHLOE
Emma? You there?

> *One hour passes.*

CHLOE
Sorry. You're probably busy.

> *Another hour. Chloe stares at the phone.*

CHLOE
Forget I disturbed you.

> *In Lagos, Emma finally comes out of a meeting and turns her phone over. Three messages. Her face falls.*

EMMA
Chloe! I've been in meetings all day. Is everything okay?

CHLOE
Yes. Sorry.

EMMA
That's three apologies, and you haven't done anything wrong.

CHLOE
Habit, I suppose.

EMMA
You don't need to apologise for wanting to talk to your friend.

> *Chloe reads one word again and again: "friend."*

CHLOE
Are we friends?

EMMA
After surviving almost a year of your questionable food opinions? I should think so.

CHLOE
Thank you.

EMMA
For what?

CHLOE
For not making me feel like a burden.

> *Emma stares at her phone, deeply moved.*

EMMA
Chloe, friendship isn't a burden.

> *A few minutes later:*

CHLOE
Same time next Friday?

EMMA
As often as life allows. And if one of us is busy, it doesn't mean the friendship has disappeared.

> *Chloe smiles. In her world, people who go quiet usually come back angry. This matters more than Emma will ever know.*

SCENE 16 OF 58 · 11:34–12:12

# A House Without Windows

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — CHILDREN'S ROOM — AFTERNOON — YEAR TWO

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Two. A school bus stops outside the gate. Ada, now eight, runs up the driveway with her backpack bouncing and a rolled-up paper in her hand, and bursts into the children's room where Chloe is folding tiny school uniforms.*

> *Ada (8) comes home from school and proudly hands Chloe a drawing: a beautiful house surrounded by flowers, a sun and a tree. But there are no windows.*

**CHLOE** It's beautiful, sweetheart. *(beat)* But where are the windows?

**ADA** I forgot them.

**CHLOE** *(pointing to one room)* Even this room?

**ADA** That's your room, Mummy.

**CHLOE** My room?

**ADA** The one where nobody disturbs you. *(beat)* So nobody can see in and shout.

> *Chloe's breath catches. Her eight-year-old has drawn her a gift: a room where her mother can finally have some peace.*

**CHLOE** *(pulling her close)* Thank you, my darling. It's the best room I've ever seen.

**ADA** Mummy, when I grow up, I'll build you a real one.

**CHLOE** *(whispering into her hair)* Maybe Mummy will build it first.

SCENE 17 OF 58 · 12:12–12:59

# "Remove That Sorry"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — DINING TABLE — NIGHT / EMMA'S APARTMENT — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Night. Everyone else is asleep. The dining-room light is on low. Chloe sits at the long table, where she usually serves, with her old portfolio open, pencils scattered around her, sketching with a concentration we haven't seen before.*

> *Everyone is asleep. Chloe sits at the dining table with her old portfolio open, sketching a new house: light, air, big windows and doors that open onto a garden. Her phone buzzes.*

EMMA
Friday question. If money and fear weren't involved, what would you do tomorrow?

CHLOE
I'd go back to designing homes.

EMMA
Then tell me about one.

> *Chloe looks at her sketch. Then she types, and types, and types.*

CHLOE
Open-plan. Warm lighting. Adire fabric on the cushions. A reading corner by a big window, so the morning comes in before anybody wakes up. And no locks on the inside doors, because nobody in that house would need to hide.

> *In Lagos, Emma reads it and slowly sits up straight.*

EMMA
Look at you. I've never seen you type this much!

CHLOE
Sorry 😂

EMMA
Remove that sorry immediately.

> *Chloe laughs out loud, then covers her mouth and looks at the stairs. Silence. She looks back at her sketch, picks up the pencil and writes boldly across the bottom: "Designed by Chloe."*

SCENE 18 OF 58 · 12:59–13:42

# The Call to Halima

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — GARDEN — MORNING — YEAR THREE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Three. Morning. Kunle's black SUV pulls out of the gate and the gate closes. Chloe steps out into the garden, barefoot on the cool grass among the hibiscus and ixora she planted years ago. Birds sing. She takes her phone out of her wrapper and stares at it.*

> *Kunle's car has just left. Chloe stands in the garden among the flowers she planted, with her phone in her hand. "HALIMA (UNI)." She has stared at this name for two years. She presses call. It rings. And rings.*

**CHLOE** *(whispering)* She won't answer. Why would she answer?

> *Click.*

**HALIMA** ON PHONE *(cautious)* …Chloe?

**CHLOE** *(her voice cracking)* Halima. Hi. *(beat)* I'm sorry I disappeared.

**HALIMA** ON PHONE *(a long pause, then warmly)* Chloe Adeyemi. Do you know how many times I almost drove to your house?

**CHLOE** *(crying and laughing)* Why didn't you?

**HALIMA** ON PHONE Because the last time I came, your husband told me you had a headache. For three years, you had a headache. *(beat)* Are you okay?

**CHLOE** *(after a long silence)* Can we meet? Please.

**HALIMA** ON PHONE Tomorrow. One o'clock. The café in Wuse 2. *(beat)* And Chloe? Come. Don't send a headache.

SCENE 19 OF 58 · 13:42–15:05

# The First Step

INT. CAFÉ, WUSE 2, ABUJA — DAY — YEAR THREE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The next day. A bright café in Wuse 2 with potted plants, a coffee machine hissing and soft music. Chloe walks in, scanning the room nervously, clutching her handbag. In a corner, a woman in a green hijab stands up and waves. It's HALIMA. They hug awkwardly at first, then tightly, and sit.*

> *Chloe sits across from HALIMA, her old university friend. They're halfway through lunch. So far it has been children and weather.*

**HALIMA** …and Ahmed wants to be a pilot now. Last month it was a footballer.

**CHLOE** *(smiling)* Ada wants to be an architect. She draws houses every day.

**HALIMA** Like her mother. *(beat)* Chloe. Three years. You stopped answering. Then suddenly you call me and say "please, can we meet." *(gently)* What's going on?

> *Chloe looks at her plate for a long moment. Then, very quietly, she begins.*

**CHLOE** It's… Kunle. It's not one big thing. It's a thousand small things. What I cook. What I wear. Who I call. Money for groceries, and I have to explain every receipt. *(beat)* I don't remember the last time I made a decision without being afraid of what he'd say.

**HALIMA** *(softly)* Chloe, why didn't you tell me?

**CHLOE** Because I thought you'd ask why I stayed.

**HALIMA** I'm sorry you've been carrying this alone.

**CHLOE** Sometimes I don't even know if it's bad enough to complain about. He's never… *(She stops.)* He provides. Everybody says he's a good man.

**HALIMA** *(taking her hand)* You don't have to prove your pain to me.

> *Chloe begins to cry. Not dramatically. She simply can't hold the tears back anymore.*

**HALIMA** Who told you to call me after three years?

**CHLOE** *(a small, wet laugh)* A woman who answered a wrong number.

SCENE 20 OF 58 · 15:05–16:30

# The Counsellor

INT. COUNSELLING OFFICE, ABUJA — DAY — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Weeks later. A quiet office on the second floor of a building in Garki. A potted palm stands in the corner, and soft light comes through the blinds. Chloe knocks, pushes the door open and hesitates in the doorway. The COUNSELLOR, a kind-faced woman in her fifties, rises from her chair, smiles and gestures to the seat across from her. Chloe sits on the edge of it, holding her bag on her lap.*

> *Outside in the corridor, Halima waits on a plastic chair.*

**COUNSELLOR** You said something earlier I want to come back to. You said, "I'm not sure it's bad enough."

**CHLOE** He's never hit me. So I tell myself it isn't… real.

**COUNSELLOR** Control doesn't need a fist, Chloe. When someone decides what you eat, what you spend, who you see and whether your dreams are "nonsense", that's real. *(beat)* What you're feeling has a name. And you're not the only woman in this city feeling it.

**CHLOE** *(barely audible)* I thought it was just me. That I'm just… bad at being a wife.

**COUNSELLOR** You've spent years being very good at surviving. *(beat)* Shall we start learning what your options are? No decisions today. Just information.

**CHLOE** What should I do in the meantime?

**COUNSELLOR** One practical thing. Start keeping a record. Every time he shouts, every insult, every time he takes your card or tears up your work, write it down. The date, the time, his exact words, and who was there. *(beat)* Keep it somewhere he'll never look. If you ever need it, it will speak for you.

**CHLOE** *(after a long breath)* Just information.

SCENE 21 OF 58 · 16:30–17:08

# The Workshop

INT. DESIGN WORKSHOP, ABUJA — CONFERENCE HALL — DAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A busy conference hall in a hotel in Central Abuja. A banner reads "ABUJA INTERIOR DESIGN WORKSHOP." Twenty designers talk excitedly at round tables covered in fabric swatches, paint charts and mood boards. Chloe slips in through the back door, finds an empty seat in the last row and holds her portfolio against her chest like a shield.*

> *Twenty designers sit at tables covered in fabric swatches. Chloe sits near the back, nervous, holding her portfolio. A WOMAN in bright ankara, IFEOMA, an old classmate, spots her across the room.*

**IFEOMA** Chloe? Chloe Adeyemi?! The girl who won the final-year prize?

**CHLOE** *(surprised)* Ifeoma! You remember that?

**IFEOMA** Remember? You designed that whole children's ward! The lecturers were fighting over you! *(beat)* Where did you disappear to?

**CHLOE** *(after a pause)* Marriage. Children. *(beat)* Life.

**IFEOMA** *(sitting beside her)* Well, life brought you back. *(She taps the portfolio.)* Can I see?

> *Chloe slowly opens it. Ifeoma turns the pages, silent. Then she looks up.*

**IFEOMA** My sister is redecorating her house. She's driving me mad. *(beat)* Can I give her your number?

> *Chloe stares at her as if she has been handed a key.*

**CHLOE** *(whispering)* Yes. Yes, please.

SCENE 22 OF 58 · 17:08–17:48

# "Someone Paid Me"

INT. CLIENT'S HOME, ABUJA — LIVING ROOM — DAY — YEAR THREE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Three. Chloe parks outside a modest bungalow in Gwarinpa and walks up the path carrying a tape measure and a folder. She stands in the living room she has spent six weeks transforming. Footsteps come down the corridor.*

> *A beautifully redesigned living room with warm colours, adire cushions and light pouring through big windows. A CLIENT, a former university classmate's sister, walks in and gasps.*

**CLIENT** Chloe! This is exactly what I wanted. *(spinning around)* How long have you been doing this professionally?

**CHLOE** I trained years ago. I'm just… finding my way back.

**CLIENT** Well, please don't stop. You're very good. *(She hands Chloe an envelope.)* And this is yours.

> *Chloe looks at the envelope as if it's made of gold. LATER, in her car outside, she takes a photo of the room and sends it.*

CHLOE
Someone paid me for this.

EMMA
Wait. PAID you?

CHLOE
Yes!

EMMA
CHLOE!!! You actually did it!

CHLOE
It's not much money.

EMMA
I'm not celebrating the amount. I'm celebrating you.

> *Chloe presses the phone to her chest in the car and laughs and cries at the same time.*

**CHLOE** *(to herself)* I did it.

SCENE 23 OF 58 · 17:48–19:09

# Now It's My Turn

INT. AI STUDIO, LAGOS — CONFERENCE ROOM / INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT — YEAR THREE, MONTHS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Lagos. A tense afternoon. Grey clouds hang over the studio's glass windows. In the conference room, the MANAGING DIRECTOR sits at the head of a long table and closes his laptop slowly. Emma walks in, sees his face and sits down without being asked.*

> *The studio's managing director closes a laptop. Emma sits across from him, pale.*

**DIRECTOR** We lost the contract, Emma. All of it. We'll need to cut your department by six people. *(beat)* I need you to choose which six.

**EMMA** *(stunned)* Sir, I hired half of them. I trained them. Kemi just had a baby—

**DIRECTOR** I'm sorry. Friday.

> *THAT EVENING. Emma's apartment. Her phone rings: "MUMMY."*

**MAMA EMMA** (ON PHONE) *(weak)* Emma, don't panic. It's just my sugar again. The doctor says I should stay in hospital for a few days.

**EMMA** Hospital? Mummy, I'm coming to Ibadan tomorrow—

**MAMA EMMA** (ON PHONE) You have work. Don't worry about me. *(beat)* Have you eaten?

**EMMA** *(closing her eyes)* Yes, Mummy.

> *She hasn't. She hangs up and sits in the dark. FRIDAY arrives. For once, Emma has no encouraging words ready.*

EMMA
Terrible week. No jokes today.

CHLOE
Do you want to talk?

EMMA
Not really. I'm tired of being the person who always knows what to do.

CHLOE
Then don't know what to do today.

> *Emma stares at the message.*

CHLOE

You once told me I didn't have to earn kindness. That applies to you too.

*Emma's eyes fill with tears.*

EMMA

Look at you giving me my own advice.

CHLOE

Somebody has to. Your advice is expensive.

EMMA

You haven't paid me a kobo.

CHLOE

And I never will 😂

*Emma laughs through her tears. Later that evening, another message.*

CHLOE

Have you eaten?

EMMA

No.

CHLOE

Jollof or fried rice?

EMMA

(laughing, wiping her face) Don't start.

SCENE 24 OF 58 · 19:09–20:15

# Six Names

INT. AI STUDIO, LAGOS — CONFERENCE ROOM — FRIDAY

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Friday morning. Emma marches down the studio corridor, past her team's desks, holding a printed spreadsheet. Her people look up nervously as she passes. She knocks once on the managing director's glass door and walks in without waiting.*

> *Emma stands in front of the managing director with a printed spreadsheet, determined.*

**DIRECTOR** Emma, I asked for six names.

**EMMA** I know, sir. I've brought you two. And a plan. *(She slides it across.)* If my team takes the Nollywood animation contract we turned down last year, and I take a pay cut, we can keep four of the six.

**DIRECTOR** *(surprised)* A pay cut? Yours?

**EMMA** Kemi just had a baby, sir. Daniel is supporting his whole family in Ibadan. *(beat)* Somebody told me this week that I don't have to be the person who always knows what to do. *(beat)* But I do know what to do about this.

> *The director reads the plan for a long time.*

**DIRECTOR** *(slowly)* Four out of six. *(beat)* Fine. Make it work.

> *LATER. Emma texts from the stairwell, grinning.*

EMMA
I saved four jobs today. Four.

CHLOE
Of course you did. (beat) You keep saving people, Emma. One day somebody needs to save you back.

EMMA
(looking at the screen) Somebody already does. Every Friday.

SCENE 25 OF 58 · 20:15–21:04

# "Who Gave You Permission?"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — DINING ROOM — EVENING — YEAR FOUR

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Four. Evening. Rain has just stopped, and the garden lights reflect in puddles on the driveway. Inside, the dining table is covered in design boards, fabric samples and a neatly bound proposal. The front door opens. Kunle walks in, drops his car keys in the crystal bowl and stops at the table.*

> *Chloe has finished several small projects. She's more animated with the children and has started going to design workshops. Tonight, her proposal for a client's office is spread across the dining table. Kunle comes home and picks it up.*

**KUNLE** What's this?

**CHLOE** A proposal for a client's office.

**KUNLE** Client?

**CHLOE** Yes. I'm taking on some design work.

**KUNLE** *(slowly)* And when were you planning to discuss this with me?

**CHLOE** I was going to tell you when—

**KUNLE** You think because somebody gave you a little money, you can suddenly do whatever you want?

> *Chloe is silent.*

**KUNLE** Who put this nonsense in your head?

> *He pushes the proposal aside. Pages slide onto the floor.*

**KUNLE** Don't forget who provides for this family.

> *Chloe looks at the pages on the floor. Then, for the first time, she doesn't apologise.*

**CHLOE** I haven't forgotten. *(beat)* But I would like to work again.

> *Kunle looks at her as if a stranger has walked into his house.*

**KUNLE** *(very quietly)* We will discuss this later.

> *He walks out. Chloe kneels and gathers her pages with shaking hands. Ada watches from the stairs.*

**ADA** *(whispering)* Mummy, you didn't say sorry.

**CHLOE** *(looking up at her)* No, baby. I didn't.

SCENE 26 OF 58 · 21:04–22:29

# "My Voice Was Shaking"

INT. ADEYEMI HOUSE — BATHROOM / EMMA'S APARTMENT — FRIDAY NIGHT — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Later that Friday night. The house is silent. Chloe walks quietly down the corridor, steps into the bathroom and locks the door behind her. She sits on the closed toilet lid in the soft light, takes a small blue notebook from her makeup bag and opens it on her knee. In Lagos, Emma is curled on her sofa under a blanket.*

> *She writes in tiny, careful handwriting:*

**CHLOE** *(whispering as she writes)* "Friday. 8:40 p.m. He threw my proposal on the floor. He said, 'Who put this nonsense in your head?' Ada was on the stairs."

> *She closes the notebook, slips it back into the makeup bag under the lipsticks, and picks up her phone.*

CHLOE
I said what I wanted. My voice was shaking.

EMMA
You can be frightened and still deserve to be heard.

CHLOE
I thought getting stronger would mean I wasn't afraid anymore.

EMMA
Perhaps sometimes it means taking a small step even while you're afraid. (beat) But please be careful. Your safety and the children's safety come before any argument.

CHLOE
I've spoken to a counsellor. And Halima knows what's happening. (beat) And I've started writing everything down. Every shout. Every insult. Dates and times. The counsellor said one day it might speak for me.

EMMA
That's brave and smart. Keep it somewhere he'd never think to look.

CHLOE
Under my lipsticks. He has never once looked at my lipsticks.

EMMA

I'm glad you have people there with you. (beat) Promise me something?

CHLOE

What?

EMMA

If you ever don't feel safe, you call Halima first. Not me. Somebody who can be at your door in ten minutes.

CHLOE

I promise.

> *Chloe looks across at her portfolio on the bathroom shelf. The journey is nowhere near over. But she can see herself starting to change.*

SCENE 27 OF 58 · 22:29–23:09

# The Card

INT. SUPERMARKET, ABUJA — CHECKOUT — DAY — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Weeks later. A busy supermarket in Wuse on a Saturday morning. Fluorescent lights hum, and a trolley wheel squeaks. Shoppers queue at every till. Chloe pushes a full trolley to the checkout while Ada and Tobi argue over a packet of biscuits.*

> *A full trolley. Ada and Tobi stand beside Chloe. The cashier swipes her card. Beep. Declined. She tries again. Declined.*

**CASHIER** Madam, it's not going.

**CHLOE** *(embarrassed)* It must be the network. Let me call my husband.

> *She steps aside and calls. He answers on the first ring, calm.*

**KUNLE** (ON PHONE) I blocked the card.

**CHLOE** *(whispering)* Kunle, I'm at the checkout. The children are here. People are watching.

**KUNLE** (ON PHONE) You have clients now, don't you? Let your clients buy the groceries. *(beat)* Or come home and we'll discuss your "career."

> *Click. Chloe stands frozen. Behind her, a queue of people stares. Tobi tugs her wrapper.*

**TOBI** Mummy, can we still buy the biscuits?

> *Chloe opens her handbag and takes out the envelope from her first client, the money she had been saving. She counts the notes, hands them to the cashier and pays for everything herself.*

**CHLOE** *(quietly, to herself)* Yes, Tobi. We can buy the biscuits.

SCENE 28 OF 58 · 23:09–23:42

# Three Fridays

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT / AI STUDIO, LAGOS — END OF YEAR FOUR

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The end of Year Four. Three Fridays in Lagos. The studio and Emma's apartment both feel emptier than usual. Each Friday at the same time, Emma looks at her phone, and each Friday the screen stays dark.*

> *FRIDAY ONE.*

EMMA
Morning, Abuja. What's the food controversy today?

> *No reply. Emma checks her phone between meetings. Nothing.*

> *FRIDAY TWO.*

EMMA
Missing our usual nonsense. Hope you're okay.

> *No reply.*

**BISI** Still nothing?

**EMMA** *(trying to sound casual)* She's probably busy. Children. Life.

**BISI** *(watching her)* You've checked that phone forty times today.

> *FRIDAY THREE. Emma sits on her bed late at night and types slowly.*

EMMA
Chloe, I'm worried. You don't owe me a reply. But if you can, please let me know you're safe.

> *A whole weekend passes. On Sunday night, Emma does something she has done only a few times in four years. She calls. It rings. And rings. No answer.*

**EMMA** *(whispering to the phone)* Please. Please be okay.

SCENE 29 OF 58 · 23:42–24:44

# What Happened in Abuja

MONTAGE — ABUJA — THOSE THREE WEEKS — FRAGMENTS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Abuja, during those same three silent weeks. We see only pieces of what happens: a kitchen, a corridor at night, an office, a front door. Each moment is short and tense.*

> *FRAGMENT ONE. A dinner table with an unfinished meal. Kunle's chair is pushed back. Chloe sits very still.*

**KUNLE** I've cancelled the children's school trip. And your little "client" called. I told her you're no longer available.

**CHLOE** *(quietly)* You had no right.

**KUNLE** I have every right. This is my house. My money. My name. *(beat)* You'll stop this design nonsense, or I'll stop it for you.

**CHLOE** *(standing)* Then I'll stop living in your house.

**KUNLE** *(laughing coldly)* And go where? With what? *(beat)* If you walk out of this house, don't think you'll walk back in.

**CHLOE** *(after a long silence)* I know.

> *FRAGMENT TWO. A suitcase beside a doorway at night. Ada, now 11, holds Tobi's hand.*

**ADA** *(whispering)* Mummy, are we going on holiday?

**CHLOE** *(zipping the suitcase)* Something like that, my love. Somewhere quiet.

**TOBI** Is Daddy coming?

**CHLOE** *(after a pause)* Not this time.

> *FRAGMENT THREE. A legal adviser's office. Chloe sits across a desk, holding a tissue.*

**LEGAL ADVISER** You have rights, Mrs. Adeyemi. And so do your children. Let's write everything down. Start from the beginning.

> *FRAGMENT FOUR. Night. A front door opens. Halima stands there in her nightgown. She sees Chloe, the suitcase and the children, and immediately pulls them all into her arms.*

**HALIMA** Come in. Come in. *(beat)* You're safe here.

SCENE 30 OF 58 · 24:44–25:59

# "I'm Still Here"

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — MONDAY, 6:12 AM / INT. HALIMA'S GUEST ROOM, ABUJA — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Monday dawn in Lagos. Emma's apartment is grey with early light. She stands at the bathroom mirror half-dressed for work, toothbrush in her mouth, her phone propped against the sink. In Abuja, in a small, borrowed guest room at Halima's house, Chloe sits on a narrow bed with her children asleep beside her.*

> *Emma is getting ready for work, phone in hand, when it lights up.*

CHLOE
I'm still here.

> *Emma sits down on the edge of her bed.*

CHLOE
The children and I are safe. We're staying with Halima for now.

EMMA
I'm so glad to hear from you. How are you all holding up?

CHLOE
Scared. Confused. I cried almost the whole night.

EMMA
I'm listening.

> *In Abuja, Chloe sits on a borrowed bed with both children asleep beside her. She types a long message. For the first time, she doesn't make it smaller than it was.*

CHLOE
I didn't tell you, but for weeks it got worse. He took my card. He went through my things. He told the children Mummy was "confused." And one night he said if I left, I'd never see them again. (beat) I stood in the kitchen with my hands shaking and I thought, if I stay, Ada will learn this is what love looks like. (beat) So I called Halima. Like I promised you.

EMMA
(through tears) You kept your promise.

CHLOE

I don't know whether I can do this, Emma.

EMMA

You don't have to work out your whole future this week. Keep talking to the people helping you there. One day at a time, Chloe.

> *Chloe presses the phone to her chest. On the wall beside her is Halima's calendar. She takes a pen and circles the coming Friday.*

SCENE 31 OF 58 · 25:59–26:38

# The Borrowed Bed

INT. HALIMA'S GUEST ROOM, ABUJA — NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Night at Halima's house. The guest room is small but warm, with a ceiling fan turning slowly and a night light glowing in the corner. Ada and Tobi share one single bed under a borrowed blanket. Chloe sits on the edge, still in her day clothes.*

> *Ada (11) and Tobi (8) lie squeezed together on one bed. Chloe sits on the edge, stroking Tobi's hair.*

**TOBI** Mummy, is Daddy angry?

**CHLOE** *(carefully)* Daddy is… having big feelings. That's not your job to fix, my love.

**TOBI** Did I do something wrong?

**CHLOE** *(firmly, kneeling to his eye level)* No. Never. Not one thing. *(beat)* Grown-ups made this decision. Not children.

> *Tobi nods sleepily and closes his eyes. Ada stays awake, staring at the ceiling.*

**ADA** *(whispering)* Mummy?

**CHLOE** Yes, baby?

**ADA** It's quiet here.

**CHLOE** *(softly)* Is that bad?

**ADA** *(after a long pause)* No. *(beat)* I didn't know houses could be this quiet without being scary.

> *Chloe turns away so her daughter won't see her cry. She kisses Ada's forehead.*

**CHLOE** Go to sleep, my darling. Nobody will shout tonight.

SCENE 32 OF 58 · 26:38–28:17

# "I Want My Children"

INT. ZAINAB'S CHAMBERS, ABUJA — DAY — YEAR FIVE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Five. The chambers of a law firm in Maitama, with bookshelves full of law reports and a large wooden desk. ZAINAB, Chloe's solicitor, in a navy suit, walks briskly into her office carrying a thick file and a cup of tea. Chloe is already waiting in the chair across the desk. Zainab sits, opens the file, puts on her reading glasses and looks up.*

**ZAINAB** I want to be clear with you. This may take time. Kunle could dispute what happened, and we'll need to work carefully through the evidence and the children's arrangements.

**CHLOE** He says he'll make sure I never see the children again.

**ZAINAB** Threats are not court orders. We'll discuss what steps are available and what best protects you and the children.

**CHLOE** He knows people. Important people. Commissioners come to his house for dinner. I cook for them.

**ZAINAB** I understand why you're worried. But let's deal with what we can establish and what we can do.

> *Chloe looks down at her hands.*

**CHLOE** For years, he told me nobody would believe me.

**ZAINAB** *(closing the file and leaning forward)* I'm listening to you now.

> *Chloe begins to cry. Then she wipes her eyes, opens her handbag and places three small blue notebooks on the desk, one after another. Then her phone.*

**CHLOE** I didn't only tell myself. I wrote it down. *(beat)* Two years of records. Every time he shouted. Every derogatory thing he said: "useless", "confused", "you can't even choose what to cook." The date, the time, his exact words, and who was in the room. *(She taps the phone.)* And forty-one voice recordings. His shouting, from the kitchen, the bedroom, the car.

> *Zainab slowly opens the first notebook and turns the pages. Tiny, careful handwriting. Dates. Times. Quotes. Her eyebrows rise.*

**ZAINAB** *(quietly)* Chloe. Do you know what this is?

**CHLOE** My diary of the worst years of my life.

**ZAINAB** *(looking up)* It's evidence. Consistent, dated, written at the time it happened. *(beat)* He told you nobody would believe you. *(She lays her hand on the notebooks.)* These will make them believe you.

SCENE 33 OF 58 · 28:17–29:04

# The Call From Kunle

INT. HALIMA'S HOUSE — BACK GARDEN — EVENING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Evening in Halima's back garden. Mango trees, a small vegetable patch and the call to prayer drifting in from a distant mosque. Halima waters tomato plants with a green watering can. Chloe sits on the back step with a cup of tea going cold beside her. Her phone, face up on the step, starts to ring.*

> *Chloe's phone rings: "KUNLE." She looks at it. Halima, watering plants, looks at her.*

**HALIMA** You don't have to answer.

**CHLOE** *(taking a breath)* I know. *(She answers.)* Hello, Kunle.

**KUNLE** *(warm, reasonable)* Chloe. Enough of this drama. Come home. The children need their routine. I've been patient.
ON PHONE

**CHLOE** I've filed for divorce, Kunle.

> *Silence on the line.*

**KUNLE** *(the warmth gone)* You've what?
ON PHONE

**CHLOE** My lawyer will contact your lawyer.

**KUNLE** Your lawyer? With whose money? *(a cold laugh)* Chloe, you can't even choose between jollof and fried rice without calling me. And now you want to go to court? Against me?
ON PHONE

> *Chloe closes her eyes. Then she opens them.*

**CHLOE** *(quietly, steadily)* You're right. I used to call you. *(beat)* I don't anymore.

> *She hangs up. Her hand shakes. Halima puts down the watering can and hugs her.*

**HALIMA** Did you hear yourself?

**CHLOE** *(a shaky laugh)* I did.

SCENE 34 OF 58 · 29:04–30:15

# "What Will People Say?"

INT. HALIMA'S SITTING ROOM — DAY — DAYS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Days later. The doorbell rings at Halima's house. Halima opens the door, and AUNTY BOLA, Kunle's elder sister, sweeps in wearing a huge gold gele and holding her handbag like a weapon. She doesn't wait to be offered a seat. She lowers herself onto the sofa. Chloe comes in from the kitchen, wipes her hands, greets her respectfully and sits opposite.*

> *Halima hovers in the kitchen doorway, pretending to dry a plate.*

**AUNTY BOLA** Chloe, my dear. I've come in peace. *(beat)* Every marriage has its troubles. You think my own husband is a saint? We endure. That's what women do.

**CHLOE** *(politely)* Thank you for coming, Aunty.

**AUNTY BOLA** Divorce? In this family? Do you know what people are saying at church? That you've gone mad. That a man in Lagos is filling your head with rubbish.

**CHLOE** *(a small smile)* A woman, Aunty. And she never once told me to leave. She only asked if I was safe.

**AUNTY BOLA** Safe? Kunle has never laid a finger on you!

**CHLOE** *(calmly)* No, Aunty. He just laid his hand on everything else. *(beat)* My money. My friends. My work. My voice. *(beat)* I'm not asking anybody to understand. I'm only telling you I'm not going back.

> *Aunty Bola stares at her. She opens her mouth, then closes it. She picks up her handbag and stands.*

**AUNTY BOLA** *(at the door, quietly, not turning around)* You were always the clever one in this family, Chloe. *(beat)* I hope it serves you better than it served me.

> *She leaves. Chloe sits very still. Halima walks over and puts a hand on her shoulder.*

SCENE 35 OF 58 · 30:15–30:49

# The Edge of Something Enormous

INT. HALIMA'S GUEST ROOM / EMMA'S APARTMENT — FRIDAY NIGHT — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Friday night. Halima's guest room. The children are asleep. Chloe sits by the window with her phone, the Abuja night quiet outside. In Lagos, Emma sits up in bed with her laptop open, work forgotten.*

CHLOE
I've started divorce proceedings.

EMMA
How do you feel?

CHLOE
Like I'm standing at the edge of something enormous.

EMMA
Do you wish you hadn't started?

CHLOE
No. I'm just afraid of what comes next.

EMMA
Then we'll keep talking as you go. And please let Zainab and the people there help you with the hard decisions.

> *Chloe replies with only a heart: ❤️*

> *In Lagos, Emma looks at the heart for a long time. She opens a drawer and takes out a printed photo she has never shown anyone: a screenshot of the very first message. "Jollof rice or fried rice? Sorry, I forgot which one you wanted." She pins it to the wall above her desk.*

SCENE 36 OF 58 · 30:49–32:36

# The Hearing

INT. HIGH COURT, ABUJA — COURTROOM — DAY — YEAR FIVE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Five. The High Court in Abuja. Heavy wooden doors swing open into a wood-panelled courtroom with a raised bench and ceiling fans turning slowly. Kunle walks in first in an expensive suit, shaking hands, confident. Chloe follows with Zainab, who carries a box file. Halima takes a seat in the public gallery. Everyone rises as the JUDGE enters and sits.*

> *A formal courtroom. Kunle sits with his lawyer, immaculate and calm. Chloe sits with Zainab, composed but visibly nervous. Halima is in the gallery.*

**KUNLE'S LAWYER** My Lord, my client has always provided for his family. A beautiful home. The best schools. A driver. Everything a wife could want. *(beat)* Mrs. Adeyemi left that home without warning, taking the children with her. My client simply wants his family back.

**JUDGE** Mrs. Adeyemi. The court would like to hear from you about your experience of the marriage.

> *Chloe stands. She takes a long moment.*

**CHLOE** My Lord, for a long time, I thought a good wife was someone who never upset her husband. So I stopped disagreeing. Then I stopped asking. *(beat)* Eventually, I stopped recognising myself.

> *The courtroom is quiet.*

**CHLOE** He's right. He provided. A beautiful house. *(beat)* My daughter once drew that house for me, My Lord. She forgot to draw any windows. When I asked why, she said it was so nobody could see in and shout.

> *Kunle shifts in his seat.*

**CHLOE** I don't want to punish my husband. I want a safe and stable life for our children. *(beat)* And I want the freedom to live my own life.

> *She sits down. Zainab squeezes her hand under the table, then rises.*

**ZAINAB** My Lord, the petitioner kept a contemporaneous record of the respondent's conduct. Three notebooks, two hundred and fourteen dated entries, and forty-one audio recordings. Exhibits C to F. *(beat)* With the court's permission, one entry.

**JUDGE** Proceed.

**ZAINAB** *(reading)* "Tuesday, 7:15 a.m. He said in front of the children, 'Your mother can't even choose between jollof and fried rice without me. That's how useless she is.' Ada cried in the car."

> *Silence in the courtroom. Kunle's lawyer leans over to whisper to him. Kunle stares at the notebooks on the clerk's table and, for the first time, doesn't look confident.*

SCENE 37 OF 58 · 32:36–33:08

# "I Am So Tired"

INT. HALIMA'S GUEST ROOM / EMMA'S CAR, LAGOS — FRIDAY NIGHT — YEAR SIX

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Months pass. Hearings, adjournments, more hearings. Zainab's file grows thicker: Chloe's three blue notebooks, the voice recordings, Halima's statement and the counsellor's report. Late one Friday night in Halima's guest room, Chloe walks in, drops her handbag on the floor and lies down on the bed without taking off her shoes.*

> *Months of hearings. Chloe's notebooks and recordings were read into the record, and Kunle's lawyer fought every page. Adjournments. Chloe lies on the bed fully dressed, too tired to change.*

CHLOE
I am so tired.

EMMA
I know.

CHLOE
Everybody keeps telling me to be strong.

EMMA
Then I won't tell you that today.

CHLOE
What will you tell me?

EMMA
Eat something. Rest if you can. Speak to Zainab about what happens next. You don't have to perform strength for me.

> *Chloe reads it twice. Then she gets up, goes to the kitchen and makes herself a plate of food. For herself.*

SCENE 38 OF 58 · 33:08–33:56

# "Let's Go Home"

INT. COURTROOM → EXT. COURT STEPS, ABUJA — DAY — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

*Weeks later. The same courtroom, packed and silent. Chloe sits beside Zainab with her hands folded tightly in her lap. Kunle sits across the aisle staring straight ahead. The Judge looks up from her papers, adjusts her glasses and begins to read.*

**JUDGE** Having considered the children's welfare and the evidence before this court, the marriage is dissolved. The children, Ada and Tobi Adeyemi, will primarily live with their mother, with appropriate arrangements made for their father.

*Chloe sits completely still. Zainab gently touches her arm.*

**ZAINAB** Chloe?

**CHLOE** *(barely audible)* It's over?

**ZAINAB** This part is over. You can begin the next chapter.

*Kunle walks past their table without looking at her. Chloe watches him go and feels, for the first time, nothing but quiet.*

*OUTSIDE. The sun is bright over Abuja. Ada and Tobi break away from Halima and run into Chloe's arms.*

**ADA** Mummy, can we go home?

**CHLOE** *(holding both of them)* Yes, darling. *(beat)* Let's go home.

*THAT EVENING.*

CHLOE
We have a home. The children are with me. We did it.

EMMA
You did it, Chloe. You and everyone who stood beside you. I'm so proud of you.

*Chloe reads the message three times, then laughs and cries at the same time. For the first time in years, her tears taste of relief.*

SCENE 39 OF 58 · 33:56–34:41

# The Handover

EXT. HALIMA'S GATE, ABUJA — SATURDAY MORNING — WEEKS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *A bright Saturday morning, weeks later. Kunle's black SUV pulls up outside Halima's gate and the engine idles. The gate opens. Chloe walks out holding Tobi's hand, with Ada beside her, each child carrying a small weekend bag.*

> *Kunle's car waits at the gate for his first weekend with the children. Chloe walks Ada and Tobi out with their small bags. Kunle gets out of the car, smiling and charming.*

**KUNLE** Chloe. You look… well.

**CHLOE** Thank you. *(to the children)* Bags, water bottles, Tobi's inhaler is in the front pocket.

**KUNLE** *(lowering his voice)* You know, it doesn't have to be like this. I've been thinking. We could try again. For the children.

**CHLOE** *(calmly)* The children will be back on Sunday at six, Kunle. *(beat)* Please make sure Tobi eats something that isn't sweets.

> *Kunle stares at her. He has never heard this voice before: calm, unafraid, polite and final.*

**KUNLE** *(stiffly)* Sunday at six.

**ADA** *(hugging her mother)* Bye, Mummy.

**CHLOE** Bye, my darling. Have fun.

> *The car drives away. Halima comes out with two cups of tea.*

**HALIMA** How do you feel?

**CHLOE** *(watching the road)* Like I just made a decision. *(beat)* And nobody shouted.

ACT THREE

# Learning to Live Again

SCENE 40 OF 58 · 34:41–35:30

# A Room of Her Own

INT. CHLOE ADEYEMI INTERIORS, ABUJA — MORNING — YEAR SEVEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Seven. Morning in Wuse. Chloe walks up to a small shop front with a new sign above the door and stops to look at it for a moment. She takes out a key, unlocks the door and steps inside. The office smells of fresh paint.*

> *Chloe unlocks the door of a modest office. A small sign reads "CHLOE ADEYEMI INTERIORS." Her first employee, a young man called SEGUN, is setting up a laptop. Fabric samples lie on a table. A framed drawing hangs on the wall: a house with no windows, signed "Ada, age 8." Beside it is Chloe's own sketch of the same house, now with big windows.*

**SEGUN** Good morning, madam! The printer is refusing to work again.

**CHLOE** *(laughing)* Of course it is.

> *Her phone buzzes.*

EMMA
Madam CEO! How's the empire?

CHLOE
The empire currently has one employee and a printer that refuses to work.

EMMA
Every empire starts somewhere. Have you tried threatening the printer?

CHLOE
Emma! 😂

> *Later, another message.*

EMMA
Seriously, are you happy?

> *Chloe looks across the office at Segun laughing with a client on the phone.*

CHLOE
Not every day. I still worry about money. Sometimes I wake up afraid for no reason. But most mornings, I actually look forward to the day.

EMMA

That sounds like something worth celebrating.

CHLOE

I wish you were here.

EMMA

Me too.

SCENE 41 OF 58 · 35:30–36:17

# Seven Years, No Face

INT. AI STUDIO, LAGOS — EMMA'S OFFICE — DAY — YEAR SEVEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Seven. Lagos. Emma now has her own office with a glass door that reads "HEAD OF DEPARTMENT." She eats jollof from a takeaway pack at her desk. Bisi strolls in without knocking and leans against the door frame with her arms folded.*

> *Emma, now running her department, eats lunch at her desk. The screenshot of the first message is still pinned above it. Bisi leans in the doorway.*

**BISI** Seven years. And you've never asked for a photo?

**EMMA** No.

**BISI** Not even once? She could be anybody!

**EMMA** *(smiling)* She is somebody. *(beat)* I know her voice from our phone calls. I know her children's names, their school projects and which teacher Tobi hates. I know she can't sleep before a big presentation and that she still says sorry to printers. *(beat)* What would a face add?

**BISI** Eyebrows. At least eyebrows.

> *Emma laughs.*

**EMMA** When we meet, we'll meet. *(She looks at the screenshot.)* Some things are better when you don't rush them.

SCENE 42 OF 58 · 36:17–37:15

# Mummy's Question

INT. HOSPITAL WARD, IBADAN — AFTERNOON — YEAR SEVEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Ibadan. A bright hospital ward with white sheets and an open window. Emma walks in carrying a bag of oranges and a flask of pepper soup. MAMA EMMA, thin but smiling, sits up against her pillows and opens her arms. Emma pulls a chair close to the bed, sits and begins to peel.*

> *Mama Emma, recovering and sitting up in bed, eats oranges that Emma peels for her.*

**MAMA EMMA** You smile at your phone like a schoolgirl. Who is he?

**EMMA** *(laughing)* It's not a he, Mummy. It's my friend in Abuja. Chloe.

**MAMA EMMA** The one you've never met?

**EMMA** Seven years.

**MAMA EMMA** *(shaking her head)* You young people. *(beat)* What does she give you, this woman you've never seen?

> *Emma stops peeling. She thinks about it seriously.*

**EMMA** When I started, I thought I was helping her. *(beat)* But Mummy, I used to come home to an empty flat and talk to nobody until Monday. Now every Friday, somebody in Abuja asks me if I've eaten. *(beat)* She made me softer. I didn't know I needed that.

**MAMA EMMA** *(taking her hand)* Then she's family. *(beat)* And family should come to dinner. Tell her I said so.

**EMMA** *(smiling)* I'll tell her.

SCENE 43 OF 58 · 37:15–37:50

# Still Here

MONTAGE — LAGOS AND ABUJA — YEAR EIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Eight. A sequence of ordinary Fridays in two cities: building sites, boardrooms, sofas and kitchens. The friendship has become part of everyday life.*

> *FRIDAY, 8:07 AM. Chloe on a building site in a hard hat.*

CHLOE
Still here ❤️

EMMA
Me too ❤️

> *ANOTHER FRIDAY, 6:41 PM. Emma bursts out of a boardroom.*

EMMA
I finally got that promotion!

CHLOE
MY GIRL!!!

> *ANOTHER FRIDAY, 10:12 PM. Chloe on her sofa, exhausted.*

CHLOE
Today was difficult. I don't feel like talking.

EMMA
That's okay. Sleep well, Chloe. We can talk another time.

> *ANOTHER FRIDAY, 2:19 PM.*

EMMA
Mummy is out of hospital and fully well. She asked who "Rice Woman" is. I told her you're family.

CHLOE
(after a long pause) Tell her family says hello.

SCENE 44 OF 58 · 37:50–38:39

# "Coffee?"

INT. BUILDING SITE OFFICE, ABUJA — AFTERNOON — YEAR NINE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Nine. A dusty building site in Abuja with concrete pillars and the sound of drills. In a site office made from a shipping container, a fan rattles on a filing cabinet and blueprints cover a long table. TUNDE BALOGUN, an architect in a rolled-up shirt with a pencil behind his ear, finishes going through the drawings with Chloe.*

**TUNDE** So that's the ceiling heights agreed. *(beat)* Would you like to get coffee?

**CHLOE** *(not looking up from the plans)* Coffee? As in a meeting?

**TUNDE** Not exactly.

> *Chloe looks up and raises an eyebrow.*

**TUNDE** I was hoping for the kind where we talk about things other than ceiling heights.

**CHLOE** *(putting down her pen)* Tunde, I should tell you something. I've been married before. I have two children.

**TUNDE** I know.

**CHLOE** And I'm not looking for someone to take over my life.

**TUNDE** *(smiling)* Good. I wouldn't know what to do with somebody else's life. I'm still trying to organise mine.

> *Chloe laughs, a real, unguarded laugh.*

**CHLOE** One coffee.

**TUNDE** One coffee. *(beat)* You choose the place.

> *Chloe pauses at that, "you choose", and smiles.*

SCENE 45 OF 58 · 38:39–39:36

# "Excuse Me???"

INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE / EMMA'S OFFICE — FRIDAY NIGHT — INTERCUT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Friday night. Chloe sits on her own sofa in her own home, wrapped in a throw, phone in hand, smiling. In Lagos, Emma is still at her office desk, the building empty around her.*

CHLOE
There's someone.

EMMA
EXCUSE ME???

CHLOE
Stop shouting through the phone.

EMMA
Name. Occupation. Criminal record. Favourite rice.

CHLOE
Architect. Tunde. And before you ask, he likes both jollof and fried rice.

EMMA
Finally. A man with sense.

CHLOE
Emma!

> *Then Chloe becomes serious.*

CHLOE
I'm frightened of making another mistake.

EMMA
That's understandable. Take your time. Pay attention to how he treats you, especially when you disagree. You don't have to rush anything.

CHLOE
I told him I'm not ready to remarry.

EMMA

What did he say?

CHLOE

He said, "Then we won't discuss marriage until you want to."

> *Emma smiles at her desk.*

EMMA

And what did you think?

CHLOE

I thought it was nice to say no without being afraid of what came next.

SCENE 46 OF 58 · 39:36–40:13

# The Boy who Likes Both

INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE, ABUJA — DINING ROOM — EVENING — MONTHS LATER

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Months later. Evening. Chloe's dining room is warm and bright. Two pots sit in the middle of the table, one of jollof and one of fried rice. The doorbell rings. Tobi runs to open it. Tunde stands on the doorstep holding a bottle of malt and a bunch of flowers, nervous. Chloe calls everyone to sit.*

> *Tunde's first dinner with the children. Ada (16) watches him carefully. Tobi (13) is chatty. Chloe serves two pots.*

**TOBI** Mr. Tunde, jollof or fried rice? You have to pick. It's a test.

**TUNDE** *(seriously)* Both. Is that allowed?

**TOBI** *(to Chloe)* Mummy, is that allowed?

**CHLOE** *(smiling)* In this house, it's allowed.

**ADA** *(arms folded)* Mr. Tunde. If Mummy disagrees with you, what do you do?

**TUNDE** *(putting down his fork)* I listen. Then usually I find out she's right. It's very annoying.

> *Tobi laughs. Ada studies him for a long moment.*

**ADA** *(quietly)* And if she says no?

**TUNDE** *(gently)* Then the answer is no.

> *Ada looks at her mother. Then, for the first time, she smiles at him.*

SCENE 47 OF 58 · 40:13–40:58

# "Not Yet"

EXT. JABI LAKE, ABUJA — EVENING — YEAR NINE

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Sunset at Jabi Lake. The water glows orange and pink, and a roasted-corn seller fans her coals by the path. Couples and families stroll along the edge. Chloe and Tunde walk side by side, eating corn wrapped in paper.*

> *Chloe and Tunde walk along the lake at sunset, eating roasted corn.*

**TUNDE** My lease ends next month. I was thinking… maybe I could find somewhere closer to you and the children.

**CHLOE** *(stopping)* Tunde. *(beat)* I'm not ready for that.

> *She braces herself, watching his face for the change she has spent ten years learning to see. It doesn't come.*

**TUNDE** *(nodding, easily)* Okay. *(He takes another bite of corn.)* Then I'll renew it. My landlord will be delighted. He thinks I'm his only tenant who pays on time.

**CHLOE** *(still watching him)* You're not angry?

**TUNDE** Why would I be angry? *(beat)* You told me what you want. That's the whole point of asking.

> *Chloe looks out at the lake. Then she slips her hand into his.*

**CHLOE** *(quietly)* Thank you.

**TUNDE** For what?

**CHLOE** For letting "no" be a full sentence.

SCENE 48 OF 58 · 40:58–41:45

# The Window

INT. CHLOE'S NEW HOUSE, ABUJA — UNFINISHED ROOM — EVENING — YEAR TEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Ten. Evening. The sound of crickets. Tunde leads Chloe down a corridor of her house, his hands gently over her eyes, guiding her past ladders and paint tins into a half-built room that smells of sawdust.*

> *A half-built extension Tunde has been designing for the house. An empty frame waits for a huge window. Tunde leads Chloe in with his hands over her eyes.*

**TUNDE** Don't look yet. *(He takes his hands away.)* Okay. Look.

> *Through the empty frame, the sunset pours into the room.*

**CHLOE** *(gasping)* Tunde. It's huge.

**TUNDE** The biggest window in the house. *(beat)* Ada told me about her drawing. The house with no windows. *(beat)* So I designed you a room that's nothing but window. A room where nobody will ever disturb you.

> *Chloe turns to him with tears in her eyes. Tunde takes a small box from his pocket. He doesn't kneel. He just holds it out.*

**TUNDE** I know you said we wouldn't discuss marriage until you wanted to. *(beat)* So I'm not asking you tonight. I'm asking you to tell me when.

> *Chloe looks at the ring, then at the window, then at him. She takes the box out of his hand.*

**CHLOE** *(smiling through tears)* Then I'm telling you. *(beat)* Now. Ask me now.

**TUNDE** *(laughing softly)* Chloe Adeyemi. Will you marry me?

**CHLOE** Yes.

SCENE 49 OF 58 · 41:45–42:10

# "He Asked"

INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE / EMMA'S OFFICE — FRIDAY, 2:19 PM — YEAR TEN

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Year Ten. Friday, 2:19 PM. Chloe's kitchen is bright and full of plants. Ada (17) and Tobi (14) do homework at the island. Chloe sits at the counter, turns her hand in the sunlight to catch the sparkle, and lifts her phone.*

> *Chloe (43) sits in her bright kitchen. Ada is 17 and Tobi 14, both doing homework. Chloe's business is thriving. She photographs her own hand and sends it: an engagement ring.*

CHLOE
He asked.

> *In Lagos, Emma (45) jumps out of her chair.*

EMMA
AND WHAT DID YOU SAY???

CHLOE
Yes, you ridiculous woman! 😂

EMMA
I'm screaming in my office. Bisi thinks I've been fired.

**BISI** *(from the corridor)* Have you been fired?!

**EMMA** *(shouting back)* She said YES!

SCENE 50 OF 58 · 42:10–42:42

# "Please Come"

INT. CHLOE'S HOUSE / EMMA'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

*Moments later. In Lagos, Emma has shut her office door and sits with the phone in both hands. In Abuja, Chloe stands at the kitchen window, nervous, her thumb hovering over the screen.*

CHLOE
Emma, I need to ask you something.

EMMA
Anything.

CHLOE
Will you come to my wedding?

*Emma stops smiling. A pause.*

CHLOE
I mean it. I want us to meet.

*Emma looks at the message. She smiles, but her eyes are wet. Ten years. Ten years of Fridays. Ten years of knowing someone through words and a voice instead of a face.*

EMMA
Are you sure? What if you discover I'm a terrible person who steals food from other people's plates?

CHLOE
Emma.

EMMA
Yes?

CHLOE
Please come.

*Emma wipes away a tear.*

EMMA
Of course I'll come.

SCENE 51 OF 58 · 42:42–43:30

# What If?

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LAGOS — NIGHT BEFORE THE WEDDING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The night before the wedding. Emma's bedroom in Lagos. An open suitcase lies on the bed, half-packed. An emerald-green outfit hangs on the wardrobe door, still in its plastic cover. Emma sits on the bed, then stands, then sits again, and finally calls Bisi.*

> *An open suitcase. An emerald-green outfit hangs on the wardrobe door. Emma sits on the bed on the phone with Bisi.*

**EMMA** Bisi, what if I'm not what she imagines? Ten years of messages. She thinks I'm wise. I'm a woman who eats cereal for dinner and talks to her plants.

**BISI** (ON PHONE) Emma. She doesn't love your wisdom. She loves that you showed up. Every Friday. For ten years.

**EMMA** *(quietly)* What if I walk in and she's disappointed?

**BISI** (ON PHONE) Then she'll be disappointed for five seconds, and then she'll hug you for five hours. *(beat)* Go to sleep. Your flight is at seven.

> *Emma hangs up and looks at the screenshot of the first message, now printed and folded into her passport.*

**EMMA** *(whispering)* Jollof with turkey. *(beat)* Here we go.

SCENE 52 OF 58 · 43:30–44:00

# Arrivals

INT. NNAMDI AZIKIWE AIRPORT, ABUJA — ARRIVALS HALL — WEDDING DAY, MORNING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Wedding day morning. Nnamdi Azikiwe Airport, Abuja. The sliding doors of the arrivals hall open. Travellers stream out into the heat, and taxi drivers call out. Emma walks out pulling a small suitcase, a garment bag over her arm, and stops to take a breath.*

> *Emma walks out of arrivals with a small suitcase and her emerald outfit in a garment bag. A TAXI DRIVER waves her over.*

**TAXI DRIVER** Madam, taxi? Where are you going?

**EMMA** *(taking a deep breath)* To meet my best friend. For the first time.

**TAXI DRIVER** *(confused)* For the first time? And she's your best friend?

**EMMA** Ten years.

**TAXI DRIVER** *(grinning, opening the door)* Madam, this is Abuja. I've heard stranger things. *(beat)* Where to?

> *Emma looks at her phone. She types "On my way!", then deletes it. She types it again, and deletes it again.*

**EMMA** *(to herself)* No. Let her be surprised.

> *She puts the phone in her bag and gets in.*

SCENE 53 OF 58 · 44:00–44:52

# The Bride's Room

INT. HOTEL SUITE, ABUJA — WEDDING DAY — AFTERNOON

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Wedding day afternoon. A hotel suite in Abuja filled with flowers, steam from an iron, and laughter from the next room. Makeup brushes and hairpins cover the dressing table. Chloe sits in front of a large mirror in her ivory dress while a makeup artist works. Halima stands behind her with the veil, and Ada watches from the window seat.*

> *Chloe sits in front of a mirror in her ivory dress while the makeup artist finishes. Halima pins her veil. Ada (17), in a gold dress, holds the bouquet.*

**HALIMA** You look like a queen, Chloe. A real one this time.

**CHLOE** *(checking her phone)* She hasn't texted today.

**HALIMA** Who? Emma?

**CHLOE** Every Friday for ten years, she texts. And today, nothing. *(beat)* What if she changed her mind? What if she's scared? What if I'm too much?

**ADA** *(kneeling in front of her)* Mummy. You told me that when someone goes quiet, it doesn't mean the friendship has disappeared. *(beat)* Aunty Friday taught you that. Remember?

> *Chloe looks at her daughter and breathes.*

**CHLOE** *(smiling)* When did you get so wise?

**ADA** I've been reading your messages over your shoulder since I was seven.

**CHLOE** *(gasping, laughing)* Ada!

**HALIMA** *(laughing)* Come. Your husband is waiting. And so, I think, is your friend.

SCENE 54 OF 58 · 44:52–47:34

# The Stranger who Answered

EXT. GARDEN WEDDING RECEPTION, ABUJA — EVENING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Evening. A beautiful garden reception. Fairy lights hang between the trees, and round tables have white cloths and white flowers. A live band plays highlife softly. Three hundred guests in lace and agbada laugh and eat. The MC taps the microphone, and the music fades as the bride stands up.*

> *A beautiful outdoor reception with warm evening lights, white flowers, music, and family laughing and talking. Chloe is radiant in an elegant ivory dress. Tunde sits beside her, smiling. Ada and Tobi sit nearby. Halima and Zainab are at the front table. The MC hands Chloe the microphone.*

**CHLOE** First, thank you to everyone who came to celebrate with us. *(She turns to Tunde.)* And Tunde, thank you for loving the woman I am, not the woman you want me to become.

> *Guests applaud. Chloe takes a breath.*

**CHLOE** But before we continue, there's somebody I need to introduce. Somebody very special. *(beat)* Ten years ago, I sent a text message asking whether I should cook jollof rice or fried rice. Sounds silly, doesn't it?

> *Guests laugh.*

**CHLOE** But I wasn't laughing that afternoon. I was terrified. I'd become so afraid of upsetting my husband that even choosing what to cook felt like a test I couldn't afford to fail.

> *The garden goes quiet.*

**CHLOE** I was using a new phone. I typed one digit wrong. And the message went to a complete stranger. That stranger replied, "Wrong receiver, but jollof rice with turkey sounds better."

> *Soft laughter.*

**CHLOE** A week later, I sent another message. And she replied again. And somehow, we just kept talking. *(beat)* About food, traffic, children, work, terrible bosses, broken printers and the weather. We laughed. We argued over the most ridiculous things.

**CHLOE** And when I finally admitted I was afraid in my own home, she didn't laugh at me. She didn't blame me. She asked whether I was safe.

> *Chloe's eyes fill with tears.*

**CHLOE** She encouraged me to speak to people who could help me. She reminded me I was capable, even when I'd forgotten what that felt like. *(beat)* She was there when I went back to designing. When I earned my first money. When I started divorce proceedings. When I was afraid of losing my children. When I opened my business. And when I met this wonderful man sitting beside me.

> *She reaches for Tunde's hand.*

**CHLOE** But here's the part some of you may not believe. *(She looks around the reception.)* I have never met her.

> *The guests begin to murmur.*

**CHLOE** Ten years. Ten years of friendship, and we've never seen each other face-to-face. I asked her to come today because I couldn't imagine celebrating this moment without her. *(Her voice trembles.)* I want to introduce you to the woman who helped save my life. Not because she fought my battles for me. She couldn't. But because she reminded me, week after week, that I was worth fighting for. *(beat)* Her name is Emma. Emma Williams.

> *Chloe looks around. Silence. No one stands. Her smile begins to falter. She looks toward the entrance. Nothing.*

**HALIMA** *(whispering to Zainab)* Where is she?

SCENE 55 OF 58 · 47:34–48:04

# "Still Here"

EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION — CONTINUOUS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *The silence stretches. Every guest is looking around. Chloe stands at the microphone, her smile slowly fading.*

> *Chloe's phone lies beside her bouquet. It lights up with a new message.*

EMMA
Still here ❤️

> *Chloe gasps and looks up. At the back of the reception, a woman in an elegant emerald-green outfit slowly rises from her seat. Emma. She's smiling and crying.*

**EMMA** *(calling out gently)* Chloe?

> *Chloe puts a hand over her mouth.*

**CHLOE** Emma?

**EMMA** You still haven't learned how to cook the right rice.

> *The entire reception erupts in laughter. Chloe laughs through her tears. She steps down from the platform, gathering her dress. Emma walks toward her. They stop, facing each other. Two women who have shared ten years of their lives, who know each other's fears, humour, hopes and hard days, and who have never been in the same room.*

**CHLOE** You came.

**EMMA** Of course I came.

> *Chloe starts to cry.*

**CHLOE** I don't even know what to say.

**EMMA** Well, that's a first.

> *They laugh and embrace. Chloe holds her tightly.*

**CHLOE** Thank you.

**EMMA** For what?

**CHLOE** For answering.

**EMMA** *(looking into her eyes)* Thank you for texting back.

SCENE 56 OF 58 · 48:04–49:18

# Aunty Friday

EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION — CONTINUOUS

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Applause fills the garden. The two women hold each other in the middle of the aisle while guests wipe their eyes. Then small footsteps come running across the grass.*

> *Ada comes forward and wraps her arms around Emma.*

**ADA** You're Aunty Friday?

**EMMA** *(laughing)* I suppose I am!

**ADA** Mummy talks about you all the time. *(beat)* You're the reason she started laughing again. I was seven. I remember.

> *Emma can't speak. Tobi joins the hug. For the first time, Emma sees the children whose school stories and birthdays she has followed for ten years.*

**TOBI** You look exactly like your texts.

**EMMA** *(laughing through tears)* What does that even mean?

**TOBI** Funny.

> *Tunde approaches, smiling.*

**TUNDE** So you're the famous Emma.

**EMMA** And you're the man who likes both kinds of rice?

**TUNDE** Guilty.

**EMMA** I think we're going to get along.

> *The guests applaud. Chloe goes back to the microphone, still holding Emma's hand.*

**CHLOE** I want to say one last thing. Sometimes, when you're going through something terrible, you start to believe nobody cares. That nobody sees you. That nobody would understand. *(beat)* But please don't give up on the possibility of kindness. Talk to someone you trust. Accept help. And if someone reaches out to you, don't underestimate what it means to listen.

**CHLOE** Because ten years ago, one wrong digit sent my message to the wrong number. And somehow… *(She looks at Emma.)* …it reached exactly the person I needed.

> *The guests stand and applaud. Emma wipes away her tears.*

SCENE 57 OF 58 · 49:18–49:45

# The First Dance

EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION — DANCE FLOOR — LATER THAT NIGHT

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *Later that night. The band plays upbeat highlife and the dance floor is packed. Aunties are dancing, children are spinning, and Tunde is attempting a terrible shoki. At the edge of the floor, by the food table, two women stand side by side with full plates.*

> *Music. Everyone dances. Emma and Chloe stand at the edge of the dance floor with plates of food, laughing.*

**EMMA** *(looking at her plate)* Your caterer made jollof AND fried rice.

**CHLOE** I couldn't decide.

**EMMA** *(mock horror)* After ten years?

**CHLOE** *(smiling)* No. I decided. I wanted both. *(beat)* And nobody in this garden is going to tell me that's wrong.

> *Emma looks at her friend, really looks at her, then raises her plate like a toast.*

**EMMA** To both.

**CHLOE** To both.

> *They clink plates. Tunde pulls Chloe onto the dance floor. She reaches back and drags Emma in too. Halima, Ada and Tobi join. Everyone dances under the lights.*

SCENE 58 OF 58 · 49:45 — END

# Jollof With Turkey

INT. CHLOE AND TUNDE'S KITCHEN, ABUJA — FRIDAY, 2:19 PM — ONE WEEK AFTER THE WEDDING

☐ Images ☐ Voice ☐ Edited

> *One week after the wedding. Friday afternoon. Sunlight floods a bright kitchen with a huge window and plants on every sill, a room Chloe designed herself. Soft music plays. The back door is open, and laughter drifts in from the garden.*

> *Chloe stands in the kitchen of the home she shares with Tunde and the children. Sunlight fills the room. Music plays softly. Everything is warm, relaxed and lived-in. Tunde walks in.*

**TUNDE** Darling, what are we having for dinner?

**CHLOE** I haven't decided.

**TUNDE** Anything you make is fine with me.

> *He kisses her cheek and leaves, humming. Chloe pauses. She remembers another kitchen. Another Friday. A woman trembling as she typed. She looks around her bright kitchen and smiles. Her phone buzzes.*

EMMA
Happy Friday, Rice Woman! What's cooking? 😂

CHLOE
I haven't decided. Jollof or fried?

EMMA
Whatever YOU want, Chloe.

> *Chloe stares at the words. Her smile widens.*

**CHLOE** *(whispering)* Whatever I want.

> *She looks out the window. Then she types.*

CHLOE
Jollof rice with turkey, obviously ❤️

EMMA
Finally. Ten years to learn 😂❤️

> *Chloe laughs.*

"Sometimes, the people who change our lives arrive without an introduction."
One wrong number. One unexpected friendship. Ten years of showing up.

END

# THE END

One dead number. One unexpected friendship. Ten years of showing up.

↑ Back to all scenes